

Social and Political Philosophy

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- Social philosophy is the study of society and social institutions through the lens of ethical values. It involves analyzing how concepts like justice, freedom, and equality relate to social structures and practices. Social philosophy also involves developing theoretical frameworks to understand the social contexts of political, legal, moral, and cultural questions.
- According to Mackenzie, 'Social Philosophy seeks to explain the nature of society in the light of the principle of social solidarity'. Social Philosophy aims at interpretation of society with reference to the norm of 'social unity'.

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- **Political philosophy**, or **political theory**, is the philosophical study of government, addressing questions about the nature, scope, and legitimacy of public agents and institutions and the relationships between them. Its topics include politics, justice, liberty, property, rights, law, and authority: what they are, if they are needed, what makes a government legitimate, what rights and freedoms it should protect, what form it should take, what the law is, and what duties citizens owe to a legitimate government, if any, and when it may be legitimately overthrown, if ever.

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- The scope of this political philosophy also varies enormously. In general, we can see concepts such as the state, the relationship between government and citizens, morality, and political economy as the most crucial concepts addressed in Modern political philosophy.

The Nature of Society

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- Societies are characterized by shared values, beliefs, and norms. They are typically subject to the same political authority and dominant cultural expectations.
- The natural society is that society which human beings can build.
- The nature of society is a complex interplay of social structures, culture, and power dynamics. Through the examination of social institutions, groups, cultural elements, and power relationships, we can better understand the intricacies of human interaction and the factors that shape our societies.

Who should Rule? The Question of Legitimacy

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- Legitimacy is commonly defined in political science and sociology as the belief that a rule, institution, or leader has the right to govern. It is a judgment by an individual about the rightfulness of a hierarchy between rule or ruler and its subject and about the subordinate's obligations toward the rule or ruler.
- Legitimacy is a recognized right to rule: An authority, for example a government, is considered legitimate if people under it recognize it as rightful. Max Weber, a German sociologist, identified three basic types of legitimacy: traditional, charismatic, and rational-legal.

Anarchism, the Free Market and the Need for Government

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- The term anarchy is derived from the ancient Greek root anarchos (“without authority”), denoting the absence of the rule of law or of settled government.
- **Anarchism** is a political philosophy and movement that is against all forms of authority and seeks to abolish the institutions it claims maintain unnecessary coercion and hierarchy, typically including the state and capitalism.
- Anarchism advocates for the replacement of the state with stateless societies and voluntary free associations.

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- Anarchists consider the state as a tool of domination and believe it to be illegitimate regardless of its political tendencies. Instead of people being able to control the aspects of their life, major decisions are taken by a small elite.
- Robert Paul Wolff believed that the tension between authority and autonomy would mean the state could never be legitimate.

What is Justice?

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- Justice is a central concept in ethics, political philosophy, and legal philosophy.
- Justice is the idea that people should be treated fairly and impartially, and that the law should ensure that no one is harmed. It can also refer to the legal system that judges who should receive benefits or burdens.
- Justice is often associated with fair and impartial decision procedures, and with treating people even-handedly. It's also associated with the idea that people should be held accountable for their actions.

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- The most fundamental principle of justice—one that has been widely accepted since it was first defined by **Aristotle** more than two thousand years ago—is the principle that "equals should be treated equally and unequals unequally."

Justice and Equality

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- Equality is the condition under which all individuals receive uniform treatment, resources, and opportunities ([Georgia Institute of Technology](#)). The assumption that underlies equality is that everyone has identical needs and would benefit equally from an even distribution of resources.
- Justice and equality are both concepts that represent fairness and egalitarianism. They are related to the idea of social justice, which is about fairness and inclusion.

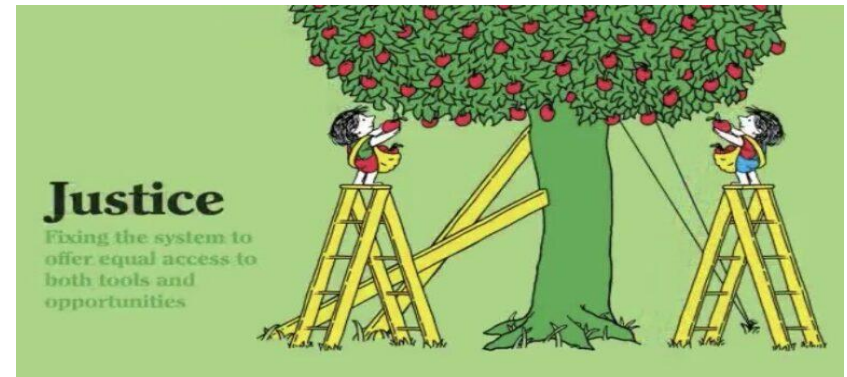
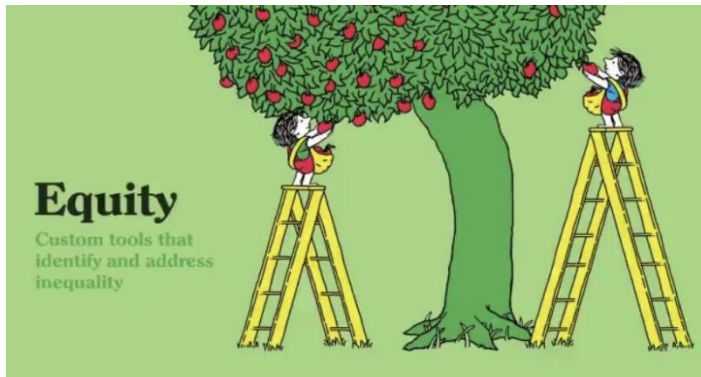
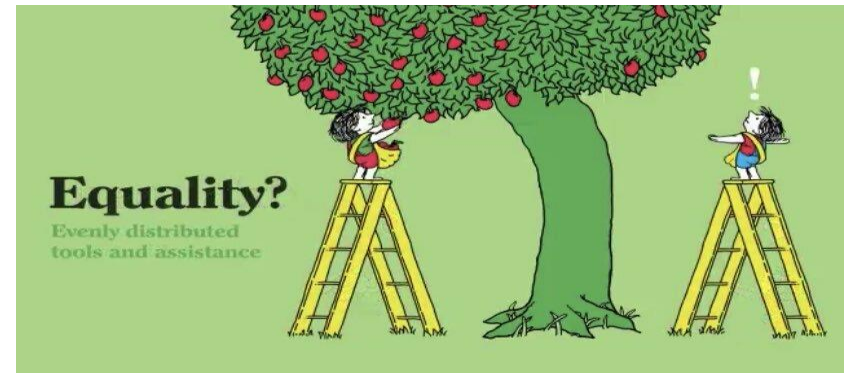
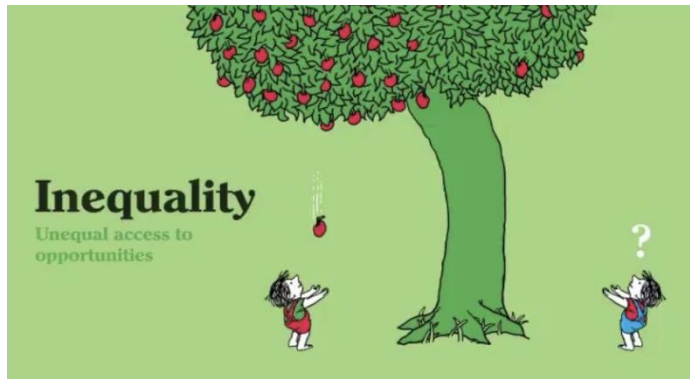
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- **Equity:** Considering people's different needs and assets, and understanding that people may need different opportunities and support.
- Some principles of social justice include:
 - **Equal access to social goods:** A fundamental principle of social justice.
 - **Diversity:** Government and business leaders should be broadly representative of the communities they serve.
 - **Human rights:** The final principle of social justice, and arguably the most fundamental.

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The Origins of Justice and the Social Contract

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- Justice is one of the most important moral and political concepts. The word comes from the Latin *jus*, meaning right or law. The *Oxford English Dictionary* defines the “just” person as one who typically “does what is morally right” and is disposed to “giving everyone his or her due,” offering the word “fair” as a synonym. But philosophers want to get beyond etymology and dictionary definitions to consider, for example, the nature of justice as both a moral virtue of character and a desirable quality of political society, as well as how it applies to ethical and social decision-making.

Social Contract

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- The idea of the social contract has its origins in antiquity, but the concept was developed during the Enlightenment and became a leading doctrine of political legitimacy in the mid-17th to early 19th centuries. The social contract theory is a way to explain the origins of sovereign power and the moral principles that make it just and legitimate.
- The social contract theory is often associated with the liberal tradition in political theory, which assumes that all people are fundamentally free and equal.

Rights and the Individual:

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- Individual rights are rights that are inherent to all human beings, regardless of their status. These rights are essential for protecting and preserving a person's humanity, and ensuring they can live a life of dignity.
- Libertarians advocate for the expansion of individual autonomy and political self-determination, emphasizing the principles of equality before the law and the protection of civil rights, including the rights to freedom of association, freedom of speech, freedom of thought and freedom of choice.

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- Liberalism is a political and moral philosophy based on the rights of the individual, liberty, consent of the governed, political equality, the right to private property and equality before the law.
- Liberalism became a distinct movement in the Age of Enlightenment, gaining popularity among Western philosophers and economists. Liberalism sought to replace the norms of hereditary privilege, state religion, absolute monarchy, the divine right of kings and traditional conservatism with representative democracy, rule of law, and equality under the law.

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- Communitarianism is a political and social philosophy that emphasizes the connection between the individual and the community:

- **Individual and community**

Communitarianism is based on the belief that a person's social identity and personality are largely shaped by community relationships.

- **Individual and collective goals**

Communitarianism aims to balance individual and collective goals and values.

- **Social formulations of the good**

Communitarianism favors social formulations of the good, rather than assuming that the good should be determined by each individual.

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- **Shared conceptions of the good**

Communitarians examine how shared conceptions of the good are formed, transmitted, justified, and enforced.

- **Moral and political judgments**

Communitarians believe that the conception of human nature should inform moral and political judgments, as well as policies and institutions.

- Communitarianism is often contrasted with liberalism, which assumes that the good should be determined by each individual.